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**Owl flies back into the wild;
raptor center frees No. 3,000**

By PAIGE WILLIAMS
Staff Writer

Jim Fowler flapped free Saturday, a bird with new purpose in a wide-open world.

This little screech owl was on his own.

He spent his first five minutes of freedom on a sweet-gum branch as bird lovers applauded the milestone — the 3,000th bird of prey released from the Carolina Raptor Center.

The real Jim Fowler — the owl's namesake and the famous naturalist and host of "Mutual of Omaha's Wild Kingdom" — led the send-off at Latta Plantation Park north of Charlotte.

He cupped the fuzzy 4½-ounce gray owl — almost full grown and no bigger than a soda can — in his hands in a hot clearing. "What a great little owl!" he said and the nervous fowl Fowler blinked and squirmed.

It climbed onto Fowler's fist and pushed off toward a grove.

He wasn't that brave 84 days ago when he came to the Raptor Center the size of a Ping-Pong ball, a newborn knocked from his nest when Pitt County loggers felled a tree.

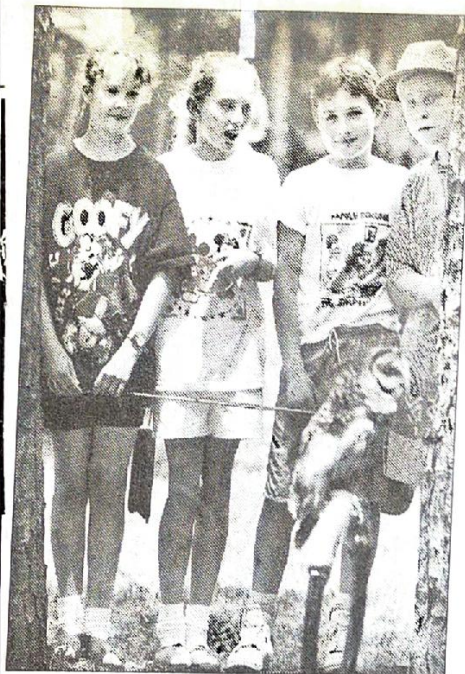
The center nursed him to near adulthood with wounded barn owls, red-tailed hawks, a proud one-winged golden eagle. That's its mission. The 10-year-old center rehabilitates sick or injured birds of prey and releases them.

This 3,000th launch merited special attention.

So who better to invite than the real Jim Fowler, an authority on predatory birds, best known for "Wild Kingdom" and introducing strange critters on Johnny Carson's "Tonight Show."

Owl Fowler was ready: beak, talons, feathers measured and a tiny U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service band clipped to his left leg.

He took off a celebrity, with 10½ weeks' worth of care, a new name and the instincts of a hunter.



T. ORTEGA GAINES/Staff

Day at the park: Belfast natives Leonne Wheatley, Clair Rois McGinnis, Paul Boyle and David Spence — all 12 years old — view birds at the Folk Music Festival at Latta Plantation Park in Charlotte on Saturday.



BOB LEVERONE/Staff

Fly away: TV naturalist Jim Fowler watches as a screech owl named for him is released from the Carolina Raptor Center. The bird, the 3,000th released from the Carolina Raptor Center, received care for 10½ weeks. Story/page 3B